

BACK TO HINDUTVA

As the battle for Gujarat heats up, Hindutva takes precedence over Chief Minister Narendra Modi's pet plank of development as he eyes the state's top post for the third time



SHAIKESH RAVAL



AP Photo/ SIDDHARTH DARSHAN KUMAR

■ By Uday Mahurkar

After keeping political analysts guessing his poll plank, Gujarat Chief Minister Narendra Modi has decided that he will return to Hindutva as the dominant theme over his developmental work in the forthcoming polls. Addressing a large gathering of businessmen, who had come together under the aegis of the Gujarat Chamber of Commerce and Industry in Ahmedabad last week to felicitate him for removing octroi, Modi brought back the Hindutva issue through the anti-terrorism route: "Remember, my Government has

given you a terror-free Gujarat when 30 per cent of the country's districts are still afflicted by terrorism or Naxalism. I have also given you a curfew-free Gujarat." Referring to the Sohrabuddin Sheikh encounter case, he said, "The anti-Gujarat lobby has been propagating that I killed Sohrabuddin. I won't allow the Congress to reach Gandhinagar through the Sohrabuddin route." The chief minister also played up the controversial Ram Setu issue on the occasion.

Call it "Secure Gujarat", which gels well with the development tune, or simply a new brand of Hindutva, Modi is at it again—of course, taking care

SPIRITED: A Congress campaign (left); Modi in a combative mode

not to use the term "Hindutva". In fact, BJP's campaign "Jeetega Gujarat" (Gujarat will win) emphasises anti-terrorism. The first three poll ad films released by BJP revolved around this issue. In one, Modi declares, "I will not spare the merchants of death in Gujarat. I will weed them out. Whatever the cost I have to pay, I want a secure Gujarat." The ads cite forceful statistics to prove Gujarat's impressive record in containing terrorism vis-à-vis the poor record of the UPA Government, playing up measures like removal of POTA as factors responsible

"The anti-Gujarat lobby has been propagating that I killed Sohrabuddin. I won't allow the Congress to reach Gandhinagar through this route."

NARENDRA MODI, CHIEF MINISTER, GUJARAT